

COMPARISON · SPLIT · STRUCTURE

compare-prose

Two prose options side-by-side with a labeled corner tag on each.

Two options, equal weight, head-to-head.

FIRST OPTION

Two-sentence description of the first option, including the strongest argument for it. Equal-density prose lets the audience compare line by line.



SECOND OPTION

Two-sentence description of the second option, including the strongest argument for it. The `chosen` or `decision` modifier marks the verdict when one has been made.

Same comparison, columns swapped.

SECOND OPTION

Now rendered on the left. Pair with `chosen` to mark the swapped position as the verdict.



FIRST OPTION

Now rendered on the right, second in the reading order. Useful when the natural argument flow wants the alternative considered before the lead.

The right card is the verdict.

BUILD IN-HOUSE

Full control of the schema and roadmap, but 2–3 engineer-quarters before feature parity.
Maintenance burden stays internal.



BUY + CONFIGURE

Ships in 6 weeks, not 9 months. Engineering capacity redirects to product-layer features; exit risk is manageable via contractual data export.

Build vs buy — decided.

~~BUILD IN HOUSE~~

Full control of the schema and roadmap, but 2–3 engineer-quarters before feature parity.
Maintenance burden stays internal.



DECISION

BUY + CONFIGURE

Ships in 6 weeks, not 9 months. Engineering capacity redirects to product-layer features; exit risk is manageable via contractual data export.

Long-body options stacked for room.

BUILD IN-HOUSE

Full control over the schema and the roadmap, with 2-3 engineer-quarters before feature parity. Ongoing maintenance burden stays internal; the team owns every escalation, every migration, every breaking change. Worth it when the data model is the differentiation; expensive when it isn't.



BUY + CONFIGURE

Ships in 6 weeks rather than 9 months, with engineering capacity redirecting to product-layer features the customer actually pays for. Exit risk is bounded by contractual data export; switching cost is a known number rather than a moving target. The right call when the data layer is plumbing rather than differentiation.

Three reasons we are building.

BUILD

The platform is the product. Owning it owns the roadmap.



WHY NOT BUY

No vendor matches our compliance posture without surrender of control.

We went with managed Postgres, not the self-hosted cluster.

MANAGED POSTGRES

Higher monthly spend, but zero on-call burden and automatic failover. The team ships features instead of babysitting replication.



~~SELF-HOSTED CLUSTER~~

Cheaper raw compute, but the operational tax — patching, backups, 3am pages — falls on a four-person team that can't absorb it.

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When NOT to reach for compare-prose.

Code comparison. Use `compare-code` for two fenced blocks. `compare-prose` is for sentences, not snippets.

Three or more options. `compare-prose` is strictly two. For three or more, use `cards-grid three` or `verdict-grid` with criteria badges.

Verbatim text differences. When the diff lives inside the prose itself — legal language, contract clauses — use `redline` so insertions and deletions render inline.

See also.

RELATED COMPONENTS

`before-after` — two states of one system, not two alternatives

`compare-code` — the columns are code, not prose

`split-compare` — the verdict needs a bottom recommendation bar

`verdict-grid` — three or more options scored against shared criteria

`decision` — the verdict slide that lands after a comparison